

Communication & Presentation

Speaking about your own work in front of a group — explaining what you did, why, and what you learned.

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...present work to a group clearly and within time.	Reads directly from a screen or sheet with no eye contact; audience cannot follow the explanation.	Makes occasional eye contact and has a loose structure but loses the thread partway through.	Looks at the audience, follows a clear arc (what I did, why, what I learned), and finishes within time.	Tailors the arc to this specific audience, anticipates a likely question, and lands the close memorably.
...use note cards as a guide, not a script.	Either reads every word verbatim or improvises with no structure at all.	Uses notes but drifts into reading them word-for-word when nervous.	Glances at note cards to stay on track but speaks in their own words; cards hold cues, not sentences.	Uses a minimal cue system that keeps eye contact nearly continuous and recovers smoothly from any stumble.
...explain the reasoning behind their decisions, not just the output.	Describes what the project is without explaining why any choices were made.	Names a choice or two when prompted but cannot explain the reasoning unprompted.	Volunteers the reasoning behind at least one key decision and can answer "why did you do it that way?" without hesitation.	Weaves decision rationale throughout the presentation, names trade-offs considered, and invites pushback.

Proficient = the competency is demonstrated reliably and independently (the target). Advanced = the student extends it unprompted.